

The Andean Yungas

A unique band of dense forest, home to many species-rich ecosystems on the side of a mountain range



The Yungas covers the eastern slopes of the Andes from northern Argentina through Bolivia and into Peru. At an altitude of 3,300–11,500 ft (1,000–3,500 m), it forms a transitional area between the Andean highlands and the eastern lowlands. In this area are many temperature-sensitive climatic zones, ranging from high, subtropical cloud forests to moist temperate woodlands. Because many animal species are confined to “shoestring distributions”—areas that extend for several miles horizontally but only a few hundred feet vertically—the biodiversity of the Yungas is very high.



TROPICAL COVER

Many species of mosses, epiphytes, and orchids thrive in the upper reaches of the cloud forest.

▷ LIFE ON THE EDGE

Steep-sided ravines like those near the ruins of Peru’s Machu Picchu create many complex microclimates. The resulting ecosystems are vital for native species.

TRADE WINDS AND CLOUD FORESTS

Warm, moisture-laden trade winds from the Atlantic form Costa Rica’s cloud forests. As warm air rises, its moisture condenses into fog clouds, creating a rainy tropical climate. Mountains prevent the clouds from entering the country’s Pacific side, so the climate is drier and less humid there.

northeasterly trade winds bring warm air from the Atlantic Ocean

clouds form on eastern side of mountains



rain-shadow area to west receives little rainfall

The Valdivian Temperate Forest

Earth’s second-largest temperate rain forest, where almost 90 percent of plant species are found nowhere else



South America’s only temperate rain forest is also one of the largest in the world, second only to the coastal temperate rain forest of the Pacific Northwest. Bordered to the west by the Pacific Ocean and to the east by the Andes, the Valdivian runs mainly along the Chilean coast, with parts stretching into Argentina. Having evolved separately from plants in the Northern Hemisphere, many species are unique to the region, including the rare Patagonian cypress (a giant conifer) and the prehistoric monkey puzzle tree.



▷ PREHISTORIC SURVIVOR

The monkey puzzle is a primitive evergreen conifer species thought to have been in existence for 200 million years.